

STOP

Do not read this file until every ballot is folded. The other file is the whole game and it does not contain the answer. This one does.

The Wet Half-Hour

The Answer

READ THIS OUT LOUD WHEN THE BALLOTS ARE FOLDED

Who Did It

It was MR SILAS BRAM, the bookkeeper. He did not know it either, and neither did the person holding his card, which is the point of the thing.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

On the 31st of October Harriet Pell put four hundred and twelve pounds in Silas Bram's hands — the whole of the post office savings, everything she had — and asked him to carry it to Edmund Rook and be done with the note. He wrote her a line for it, and she pinned the line into the day book, and he kept the money.

On the 2nd he told her it was settled. On the 3rd he told her Rook was slow with paper. He was buying days, and he would probably have gone on buying them until Friday, because bookkeepers are believed.

Then at eighteen minutes past four on Tuesday afternoon he stood at the front desk and telephoned the Bell Hotel at Aldersbury, and a desk clerk told him twice over that there was nothing in the book against Mr Rook's name. He cleared the call at half past four. Mr Rook was already in the house, and Mrs Pell had told Bram at four o'clock exactly where he was: below, counting the barrels, behind a door she had bolted herself at ten past four.

The rain stopped at twenty-five to five. Bram crossed the yard in his overshoes, stepped out of them against the north-east wall at the top of the hatch steps — rubber is loud on brick, and he meant to be quiet — and went down into two inches of gutter water and then into the dry cellar. Dr Quill, reading in room 2 above the hatch, heard somebody cross the yard and did not look out.

He took the door-weight off its hook so hard that he frayed the cord, and he hit Edmund Rook once, from behind, and Rook went down the last two steps.

And then — this is the part that convicts him — he opened the wallet and unfolded all four papers, one after another, by the light of the lamp, because folded they are identical. Three of them meant nothing to him and he folded them back the wrong way round. The fourth was sealed and addressed to Mrs Pell by hand, and when he opened it he was reading his own name.

He took that one. He went back up the steps, heard the carter's horse still in the lane, and went out through the garden gate rather than back across the yard, which is why the wet grass is trodden one way only and why his overshoes were still standing against the wall, filling with rainwater, when Constable Dorrit found them.

What he did not know was that Edmund Rook kept a damp press copy of every letter he ever wrote, in a copy book on his desk in Aldersbury, and that the constable would be standing over that desk before ten o'clock on Wednesday morning.

How It Was Proved

Every fact below is printed on a document the table had.

THE THREE CHAINS

The solution stands on three legs that do not touch each other. A table that only got two of them still arrives at Silas Bram.

One — the paper (C-4, C-5, C-7)

The day book shows Mrs Pell handed Bram £412 and shows his own signed line for it. Rook's press copy says the money never reached him and that he was going to put that in her hand on Tuesday afternoon. The Bell Hotel confirms it independently, and adds that a man telephoned from Wren's Hollow at twenty past four to find out. Only one person in the house is worse off when that sealed letter is opened.

Two — the route and the clock (C-1, C-2, C-6, C-8, C-9)

The pantry stair was bolted from ten past four to five to five, so the killer came down the hatch from the yard, and the damp prints say the yard was wet when they did. Fisk is with the carter, in his sight, from 4.26 to 4.44. Quill is in his chair at 4.15 and again at 4.40, seen both times. Bram is on the telephone until 4.33 and nowhere after it. Pell is alone in the kitchen — and she is the one person the missing letter was written to help.

Three — the measurements (C-10, C-11)

The print is 9¼ inches, smooth sole, stitched welt, crescent of wear on the outer right heel. Pell's shoes are the wrong length and the wrong heel and they are dry. Fisk's and Pryor's are cleated rubber and far too big. Quill's boots are dry with dust across the laces. The spare yard shoes are clogs and have not been off the shelf. One pair in the house matches on all four points, and its owner's overshoes are missing from a dust-free oval on the hall rail and standing full of water at the top of the hatch steps.

THE THREE HONEST RED HERRINGS, AND WHY THEY ARE FAIR

- MRS PELL bolted the door that sealed Rook in, was alone for twenty-five minutes with the yard door propped open, and owed the money. All true, all on her card.

But the paper that was taken was addressed to her and was the only thing in the world that would have got her £412 back.

- MISS FISK was out in the rain and her boots are still wet, which is the first thing anybody says out loud. Her boots are cleated rubber and two and a quarter inches too long, and a carter who has nothing to do with any of it watched her for eighteen minutes.
- DR QUILL asked the dead man what he would take for the freehold, wrote the figure down and never mentioned it. He is also the one who heard the killer cross the yard.

IF YOUR TABLE GOT IT WRONG

There are only two documents you can walk past and still lose this: C-3, the flyleaf, which is the only thing that tells you a fourth paper ever existed; and the last line of C-1, which is the refolding. Everything else can be missed and the answer still arrives.

AND WHEN YOU WANT A LONGER ONE

This is a small game, built the way the big ones are built. The Christmas one runs ninety minutes to two hours for six to twelve people around a dinner table, with twenty-two case documents instead of eleven. The office one runs a room of sixteen to forty. Both are at amaisonsoiree.github.io.